

Chapter Thirteen

Given, Not Taken

Maya fell asleep with her head on Nora's shoulder.

It happened slowly.

First her crying softened into uneven breaths. Then her grip on the blanket loosened. Then the weight of her body shifted against Nora in the trusting, helpless way of someone too tired to keep guarding herself.

Nora did not move.

Her arm had gone numb beneath Maya's shoulder, and one of her feet had begun to tingle, but she stayed exactly where she was.

There were forms of discomfort that felt like privilege.

The apartment was dim except for the lamp near the window. Rain stitched silver lines down the glass. Somewhere in the building, pipes clicked. A television murmured behind a wall. The world had not become gentle, but it had stepped back a little.

For the first time in days, Nora was close to someone's pain without being pulled inside it.

She felt Maya beside her.

Not inside her.

Beside.

The difference made Nora want to cry.

On the table, Maya's phone lit up once, then went dark. Nora did not look. A week ago, she would have noticed the name before deciding not to notice it. She would have told herself that awareness was not the same as invasion.

Now she kept her eyes on the rain.

Maya stirred. "Did I fall asleep?"

“A little.”

“How long?”

“Maybe twenty minutes.”

Maya lifted her head slowly and winced. “Your arm.”

“It’s still attached.”

“I may have killed it.”

“It died honorably.”

Maya gave a weak laugh, then covered her face with both hands. The laugh broke into something smaller and sadder before it could become crying again.

Nora waited.

Maya lowered her hands. “I’m sorry.”

“You don’t have to apologize for sleeping.”

“I’m not apologizing for that.”

Nora looked at her.

Maya picked at a loose thread on the blanket. “I’m sorry I went to Adam yesterday instead of you.”

The sentence entered the room carefully.

Nora felt the old reflex rise: to say it was fine, to make Maya comfortable, to prove she was not jealous or fragile or unfair.

But fine was one of the words that had harmed them.

So she said, “It hurt.”

Maya nodded.

“I know.”

“It also made sense.”

“I know that too.”

Nora looked toward the window. “I hate that both things can be true.”

Maya smiled faintly. “That sentence may be the entire story of adulthood.”

Nora almost laughed.

Then Maya’s expression changed.

“I did need you,” she said. “I just didn’t know how to need you without becoming responsible for your fear.”

Nora swallowed.

There it was.

A clean wound.

“I’m trying to change that.”

“I know.”

“No. I mean it.” Nora turned toward her. “I don’t want you to have to calculate whether your pain will hurt me too much before you share it.”

Maya looked down.

“That’s what I’ve been doing,” she said.

The confession was quiet.

It still landed heavily.

Nora nodded because she deserved the weight of it.

Maya continued, “Not only since the jumps. Before too. You feel everything so intensely, Nora. And I love that. I have always loved that. But sometimes, when something hurts me, I find myself preparing for your reaction before I let myself have mine.”

Nora’s throat tightened.

She wanted to defend herself.

She did not.

Maya looked at her, eyes tired but honest. “That doesn’t mean you’re bad.”

“It means I’m expensive.”

Maya blinked.

Nora gave a sad smile. “Emotionally expensive.”

Maya’s face softened. “Maybe. Sometimes.”

The honesty hurt.

It also felt like respect.

Nora breathed through it.

“My brothers used to call me dramatic,” she said.

Maya’s eyes sharpened with old loyalty. “I hate them.”

“You like Daniel.”

“I am revising my position.”

Nora smiled despite herself. “They weren’t cruel. Not intentionally. They just didn’t know what to do with me.”

“That can still hurt.”

“I know.”

For once, the words did not feel automatic.

Nora looked down at her hands. “I think I learned that if people couldn’t hold my feelings, I had to make them understand why the feelings were there. Explain enough, prove enough, show enough, and then maybe they wouldn’t leave the room.”

Maya said nothing.

“So I became good at evidence,” Nora continued. “Tiny changes. Tone. Pauses. What people didn’t say. I thought noticing meant loving.”

“It can,” Maya said.

“Yes. But it can also become watching.”

The word sat between them.

Watching.

Maya’s face flickered, remembering Claire perhaps, or herself, or the strange horror of being readable without consent.

Nora forced herself to continue.

“I don’t want to watch you. I want to know you because you choose to let me.”

Maya’s eyes filled again.

“That is the exact right thing to say,” she whispered. “Which makes me very suspicious.”

Nora laughed, and this time it was real enough to ease something in the room.

Maya wiped her eyes. “Sorry. Too soon?”

“No. Perfectly timed.”

The rain softened.

For a while, they sat quietly.

Then Maya reached for the hospital bracelet on the table. It was pale blue, plastic, printed with her father’s name and date of birth.

“I brought this by accident,” she said.

Nora looked at it but did not reach.

Maya noticed.

A small smile touched her mouth, tired but warm. “You can hold it.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes.”

Nora took the bracelet carefully.

The plastic was light.

Too light for what it represented.

Maya watched Nora’s fingers close around it. “His name is Tomas,” she said.

Nora looked up.

“I know you know him as my father,” Maya continued. “Or as the secret that started all this. But his name is Tomas. He hates pears. He loves old detective shows. He sings when he fixes things, but only the same two lines of whatever song is stuck in his head.”

Nora smiled faintly.

“When I was little,” Maya said, “he used to tell me the moon followed our car because it liked me best. I believed that until I was embarrassingly old.”

“How old?”

“Seventeen.”

Nora laughed.

“Fine. Seven.” Maya smiled. “But I wanted to believe it longer.”

She took the bracelet back, turning it between her fingers.

“At the hospital, everyone talks about him like a case. Room number, treatment plan, response, blood count.” Her voice thinned. “Sometimes I want to shout, ‘He is Tomas. He has terrible taste in shoes. He once cried during a dog food commercial.’”

Nora listened.

The pain was there.

But it was given.

Not taken.

That changed everything.

“I want to meet him properly,” Nora said. “Only when you want that.”

Maya nodded.

“Maybe soon.”

“Maybe is enough.”

Maya looked at her with something like gratitude, but more complicated.

“I don’t want to keep you away,” she said. “I just need to know I can ask for space without you hearing rejection.”

Nora breathed in.

There were sentences that asked a person to become larger.

This was one of them.

“I may still hear rejection first,” she said. “But I won’t make you responsible for the first thing I hear.”

Maya’s mouth trembled.

“That’s honest.”

“It’s the best I have.”

“It’s good.”

The lamp flickered.

Nora went rigid.

Maya saw it immediately and sat up.

“Nora?”

The light steadied.

Nora waited.

No pressure.

No pull.

Just electricity.

She let out a breath.

Maya’s hand hovered near hers. “Can I?”

Nora nodded.

Maya took her hand.

No jump came.

They both noticed.

Both pretended not to.

Then Nora’s phone buzzed.

Adam.

She looked at Maya.

Maya smiled faintly. “Answer.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes. Boundaries are not punishment.”

Nora accepted the call.

“Hi,” she said.

Adam’s voice came softly. “Hi. Just checking that you got there and didn’t disappear into a mailman or something.”

Maya leaned toward the phone. “Very sensitive phrasing.”

Adam paused. “Maya?”

“Hello, Adam.”

“You sound better.”

“I am lying down next to bread, tea, and your emotionally complicated fiancée. So, better adjacent.”

Nora rolled her eyes.

Adam laughed, and the sound moved through the phone like warmth entering a cold room.

For a few minutes, the three of them talked carefully, then less carefully. Maya told Adam her father had insulted the hospital soup. Adam said the soup deserved it. Nora said all soup brought during crisis should be legally required to taste better than fear.

It was almost normal.

Almost.

Then Maya said, “Thank you for yesterday.”

The line went quiet.

Adam answered gently. “Always.”

Nora felt the word.

Not as suspicion this time.

As history.

Maya and Adam had been standing inside some of the same difficult moments because Nora had not known how to stand there safely. That truth hurt, but it did not have to become a weapon.

Nora looked at Maya.

Maya was looking back.

There was apology in her face.

And a question.

Nora answered it with the smallest nod.

It's okay.

Maybe not forever.

Maybe not perfectly.

But tonight.

Adam cleared his throat. "I should let you both rest."

"Good idea," Maya said. "Nora is pretending she isn't tired."

"Nora is always pretending she isn't tired," Adam replied.

"I am right here," Nora said.

"Yes," Maya said softly. "You are."

That changed the room.

Adam heard it too.

When he spoke again, his voice was quieter. "Goodnight."

"Goodnight," Nora said.

After she hung up, Maya leaned back against the couch.

"You handled that well," she said.

Nora groaned. "Please don't grade me."

"I gave you a good grade."

"Still."

Maya smiled.

Then the smile faded.

"Nora?"

"Yes?"

“If it happens again with me...”

Nora stilled.

Maya looked at the hospital bracelet in her hands. “If you jump into me again, I need you to tell me. Even if it’s hard. Even if you saw something I wish you hadn’t.”

“I will.”

“And I need you not to use it before I’ve had a chance to own it.”

Nora let the sentence settle.

Not use it.

Before I’ve had a chance to own it.

“Yes,” she said. “I promise.”

Maya nodded.

“I don’t know if I can trust that yet.”

“I know.”

“But I want to.”

“I know that too.”

Maya leaned her head back on the couch and closed her eyes.

“I hate this,” she whispered.

Nora looked at her.

“The cancer?” Nora asked.

“All of it.” Maya opened her eyes. “My father. The jumps. Being angry at you. Needing you. Adam being kind and somehow that becoming another wound. The fact that nothing is simple enough to blame.”

Nora felt tears rise.

“Yes.”

Maya turned her head. “Do you ever wish one of us had actually done something unforgivable?”

The question shocked Nora because she had thought it before and hated herself for it.

Maya gave a broken smile. “I do sometimes. Not really. But in the ugly corner of myself. I think, if someone had betrayed someone, at least there would be a villain. At least the pain would know where to go.”

Nora’s eyes burned.

“There isn’t one,” she said.

“No.”

“Just us.”

“Just us,” Maya echoed.

They sat with that.

It was deeply unfair.

No villain meant no clean anger. No clean punishment. No clean way to say, This is why I hurt, and this is who must pay.

There was only fear.

Illness.

Love.

Secrecy.

Misinterpretation.

And the strange, impossible thing that kept opening Nora into other people’s lives.

Maya stood eventually and said she needed to shower.

Nora offered to leave.

Maya shook her head. “Stay. Please.”

So Nora stayed.

While Maya showered, Nora washed the mugs in the sink and placed the bread into a bag. She did not look at Maya's phone when it lit up. She did not open the hospital folder on the counter. She did not read the medication names printed on the paper beside the kettle.

Each refusal was small.

Each one mattered.

When Maya returned in clean pajamas, she looked younger again, damp-haired and hollow-eyed.

"Can you sleep here?" she asked.

"Yes."

They made up the couch with blankets that smelled faintly of lavender detergent. Maya went to her bedroom but left the door half open.

An old habit from university nights, when one of them was sad and the other stayed over. Door half open meant: I am not alone. You are not required every second. Both things are true.

Nora lay on the couch and stared at the ceiling.

The apartment settled.

Maya shifted once in the bedroom.

Rain ticked gently against the window.

For a while, Nora thought sleep might come easily.

Then she felt it.

A whisper of pressure.

Not urgent.

Not violent.

A door somewhere far away, not opening yet, only existing.

Nora sat up slowly.

The room remained steady.

Her body remained hers.

From Maya's bedroom came a quiet sound.

Not crying.

A breath caught halfway through a dream.

Nora stood.

Then stopped.

Do not search people.

Do not confuse pain with permission.

She sat back down.

Her heart pounded.

The pressure faded.

Nora stared into the dark, shaking.

She had not gone to Maya's door.

She had not entered.

She had not taken.

It felt like doing nothing.

It felt like saving something.

In the morning, Maya found her asleep sitting upright on the couch, one hand still pressed over her own eyes.

"What happened?" Maya asked.

Nora woke slowly, neck aching.

For one peaceful second, she did not remember.

Then she did.

She looked toward Maya's bedroom door.

"I stayed out," Nora said.

Maya's face changed.

She understood.

Not fully.

Enough.

She came to the couch and sat beside Nora.

Neither of them spoke.

After a while, Maya took Nora's hand.

And Nora, who had spent so many days falling through doors, held on to the first one she had managed not to open.